

American Exceptionalism: The Label Is the Strategy

The Gap Between Narrative and Reality

The United States Africa Command (AFRICOM) presents its continental presence through the language of a "light footprint" temporary, partner-led, and minimal in scope. In annual posture statements to Congress, officials consistently point to Camp Lemonnier in Djibouti as the sole enduring U.S. base on the continent (Nicastro & Tilghman, n.d.). Investigative reporting and declassified military documents tell a different story: a network of dozens of Cooperative Security Locations and clandestine outposts spread across the continent (The Intercept, 2018). This gap between official narrative and physical infrastructure is not accidental. It reflects a deliberate rhetorical strategy designed to obscure the scale and character of U.S. military engagement from domestic and international scrutiny. This paper takes that gap as its central focus, arguing that the "light footprint" label is less a description of military posture than a linguistic tool for managing perception and avoiding accountability.

Introducing the Logic of Appropriateness

To understand how this works, this paper draws on the Constructivist concept of the Logic of Appropriateness, developed by March and Olsen (1998). Rather than acting purely to maximize material gains as Realist theory would predict states also act in line with the behavioral expectations tied to their perceived identity. A state that sees itself as a benevolent, stabilizing power will pursue actions that match that image, not just because they are strategically smart, but because they seem appropriate given who the state understands itself to be. For the United States, the identity of the "indispensable nation" transforms military expansion from an act of self-interest into what looks like the fulfillment of global responsibility. This identity-driven logic matters because it shields policy from consequence-based critique: as long as the United States is perceived to be acting like a responsible global leader, the destabilizing outcomes of its interventions remain politically secondary. The Logic of Appropriateness, in this sense, functions as a shield as much as a motivation.

Thesis and Paper Roadmap

This paper argues that the United States deploys American Exceptionalism as a mechanism of epistemic violence that legitimizes and sustains a predatory military and economic architecture across Africa. Using a Constructivist framework, it traces a logical progression from AFRICOM's physical expansion through clandestine outposts, to the economic conditionality embedded in the African Growth and Opportunity Act (AGOA), whose eligibility criteria explicitly exclude nations that undermine U.S. national security or foreign policy interests (U.S. Committee on Ways and Means). This structure reveals that military presence and market access are not parallel policy tracks they are mutually reinforcing instruments of leverage. The paper proceeds in five stages: first, it establishes the theoretical framework through which Constructivist identity logic enables hegemonic behavior; second, it analyzes AFRICOM's operational expansion and its displacement of African security architectures; third, it demonstrates how that architecture produces a concrete structural consequence through the Training-to-Coup pipeline, examined through the 2023 Niger coup; fourth, it extends the analysis into the economic domain through AGOA's disciplinary conditionality; and finally, it makes a

prescriptive case for African Total Neutrality and Pan-Africanism as a framework for genuine sovereignty.

Constructivism and the Power to Label

Constructivism holds that the international system is not a fixed material reality but a social construction, produced and reproduced through shared ideas, norms, and identities (Wendt, 1992). Within this framework, state behavior cannot be fully explained by material capabilities alone what a state does is shaped significantly by what it understands itself to be. The United States has built and consistently performed an identity as the preeminent defender of liberal democratic order, an identity that grants it the implicit authority to classify other states. Nations are designated "strategic partners" when their governance aligns with U.S. interests, or "fragile states" and "failed states" when they do not categories that carry significant consequences for aid allocation, diplomatic recognition, and military engagement. The African Crisis Response Initiative (ACRI) illustrates this classificatory power clearly: Uganda and Ethiopia were included in the program despite failing its own stated criteria of democratic governance and civilian military control, because their value as U.S. strategic allies overrode the evaluative framework the United States had publicly established (Nsia-Pepira, 2014). Nigeria further illustrates the dynamic: during the 2023 AGOA eligibility review, U.S. officials cited religious freedom concerns and the conduct of security forces in the northwest as conditions bearing on Nigeria's continued market access external benchmarks defined and applied unilaterally, with no grounding in the African Union's own governance frameworks or Nigeria's constitutional processes. This classificatory power is what Alexander Wendt terms the social construction of political reality, and it is through this power that epistemic violence operates: not through force alone, but through the authority to define what counts as stability, legitimacy, and progress, and then to selectively apply those definitions when strategically convenient.

Logic of Consequences vs. Logic of Appropriateness

The tension between the Logic of Consequences and the Logic of Appropriateness is central to understanding why U.S.-Africa policy persists despite its documented failures. A strictly Realist account would evaluate policy by its outcomes: if AFRICOM's expansion has coincided with a dramatic escalation in regional terrorism, then the policy has failed on its own terms and should be revised or abandoned. Nsia-Pepira, writing in *Military Review* the U.S. Army's own institutional journal acknowledged as early as 2014 that U.S. militarization had produced precisely this outcome, documenting mounting instability across partner states and concluding that the policy was generating strategic backlash rather than security (Nsia-Pepira, 2014). That this critique appeared in an official Army publication is analytically significant: it shows that consequence-based failures were visible and documented within the institutional apparatus itself, yet produced no fundamental policy revision. The Logic of Appropriateness explains why. What matters is not whether the intervention produced stability, but whether the United States was seen to be performing the role of a responsible, engaged global leader. Military training exercises like Justified Accord, partnership rhetoric, and capacity-building programs all function as performances of appropriateness signals that the U.S. is fulfilling its identity obligations, regardless of their strategic effectiveness. This has a critical implication: policy failure does not automatically generate policy change, because the political and reputational function of the policy remains intact even when its stated objectives are not met. Understanding this logic is

prerequisite to understanding why AFRICOM's footprint continues to expand in the face of deteriorating security outcomes that even its own institutional observers have acknowledged.

The Network vs. The Narrative

The material foundation of AFRICOM's conceptual architecture is most clearly exposed through the gap between its stated posture and its physical footprint. The Congressional Research Service, echoing official posture statements, identifies Camp Lemonnier in Djibouti as the sole enduring U.S. base on the continent (Nicastro & Tilghman, 2024). Investigative documentation and FOIA-derived evidence, however, reveal a materially different picture: a constellation of at least twenty-nine installations, including staging areas, clandestine outposts, and Cooperative Security Locations (Turse, 2015). This discrepancy is not a product of administrative oversight it is the result of deliberate linguistic engineering that exploits the threshold between permanent presence and temporary partnership. By designating infrastructure as "Cooperative Security Locations" rather than bases, the U.S. military ensures its presence remains beneath the definition threshold that would invite international scrutiny or trigger the "imperial" label. Brown (2014) identifies this dynamic as constitutive of the policy itself: the language of partnership functions not to describe a relationship but to construct one, preserving asymmetric control while performing an appearance of mutuality. This linguistic architecture does more than manage perception; it actively forecloses engagement with the multilateral African security frameworks that already exist to govern such regional presence.



Figure 1. AFRICOM's *de facto* network of installations across Africa, including Cooperative Security Locations, staging areas, and clandestine outposts. Source: Nick Turse / FOIA requests (2015).

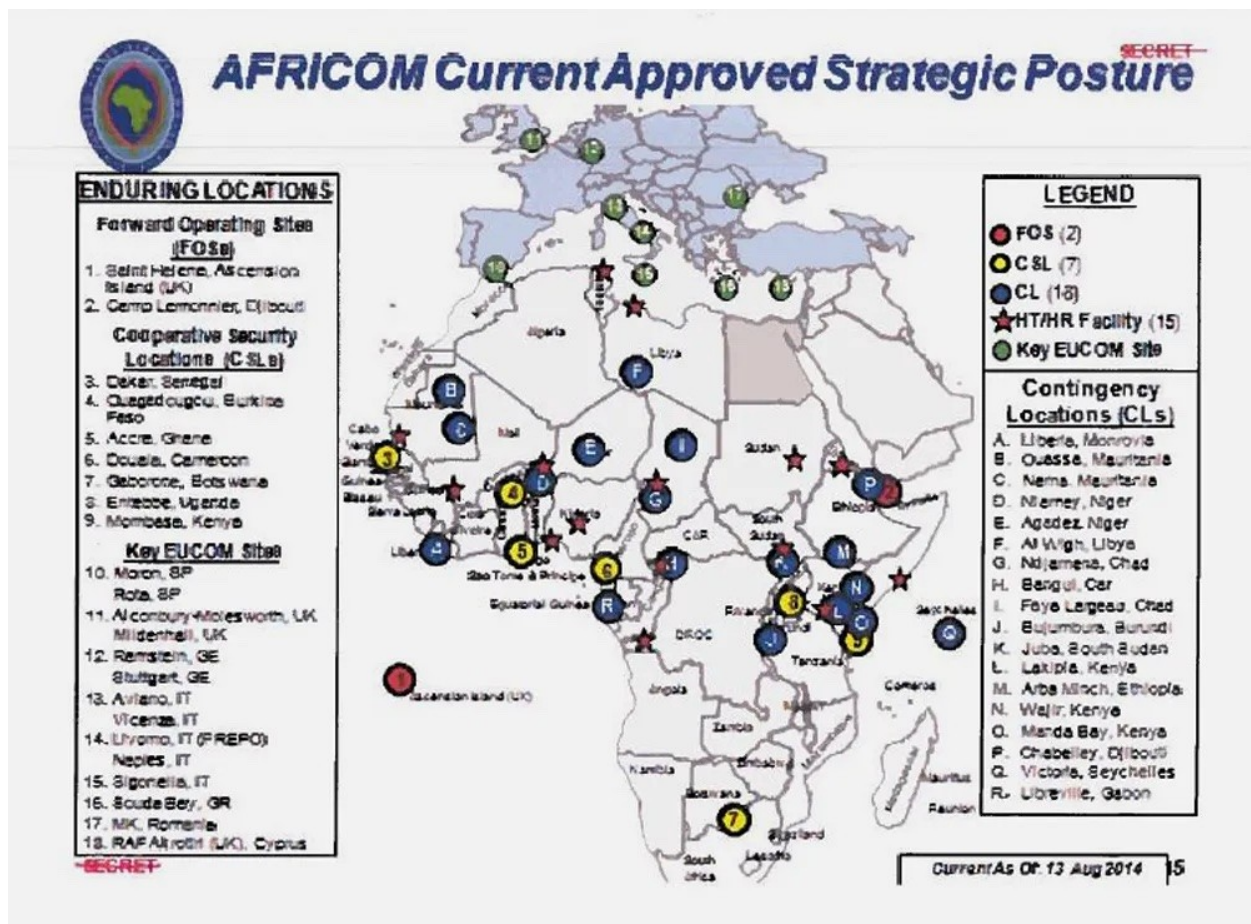


Figure 2. Leaked classified AFRICOM strategic posture document (August 2014), authenticating the network of installations beyond the officially acknowledged Camp Lemonnier.

Displacing African Security Architectures

The significance of this terminological engineering only becomes clear when analyzed against the architectures it displaces. The African Union's Peace and Security Architecture (APSA) provides a comprehensive, multilaterally negotiated framework for conflict management grounded in principles of collective security (African Union Peace and Security Department, n.d.). Similarly, the ECOWAS Policy Framework on Security Sector Reform and the East African Community's security protocols establish regional standards that prioritize civilian oversight and democratic accountability (ECOWAS, n.d.). These are not merely aspirational documents; they are the operational frameworks of a genuinely partner-led security order. AFRICOM, however, does not reinforce these systems. By constructing bilateral security relationships directly with individual governments, the United States structurally subordinates continental frameworks to its own strategic preferences, rendering them irrelevant through systematic bypassing. A security partner that consistently ignores existing multilateral institutions sends an unambiguous signal regarding their perceived legitimacy. This is the operational form of epistemic violence: the quiet institutional enactment of a hierarchy in which African-designed governance is rendered invisible by the gravitational pull of American bilateral preference.

The Militarization of Aid

The displacement of African security architectures extends into the humanitarian domain, where military logic frequently supplants civilian authority. In September 2014, the United States deployed approximately 3,000 troops to lead the international response to the West African Ebola outbreak, framing the medical crisis as a logistical emergency that only the American military could resolve (Foreign Policy in Focus, 2014). The choice to militarize a medical crisis was a political decision, not an operational necessity civilian agencies and African Union mechanisms were already available to coordinate the response. This deployment aligns with the pattern Nsia-Pepira identified as a defining feature of AFRICOM: the expansion of the military into domains previously reserved for civilian agencies, skewing developmental priorities toward security objectives (Nsia-Pepira, 2014). By routing humanitarian assistance through military command, the United States normalized the presence of troops in hospitals and community health networks. This is the Logic of Appropriateness at its most effective: by performing the role of a benevolent responder, the United States fulfills its "indispensable nation" identity while extending its institutional presence into spaces that humanitarian framing renders effectively uncontestable. The resulting military footprint grows not through security agreements alone, but through the accumulated legitimacy of good deeds.

The Great-Power Competition Frame

The Logic of Appropriateness also structures how the United States narrates the geopolitical landscape of the continent. Current AFRICOM posture statements frame the U.S. presence primarily as a necessary counterweight to the "malign" influence of China and Russia (U.S. Department of Defense, 2025). This framing positions American intervention as a defensive necessity rather than an expression of self-interest. Wight and Joseph (2024) argue that this multipolarity framing represents a qualitative escalation in which African sovereignty is increasingly subordinated to the logic of great-power competition. This is not a new phenomenon; Nsia-Pepira documented in 2014 that countering Chinese influence was already a primary driver of AFRICOM's founding rationale (Nsia-Pepira, 2014). The consequence of this discourse is an environment in which African states are denied political subjectivity they appear in U.S. documents not as sovereign actors but as terrain to be contested or secured. When the United States frames its presence as protection against external predation, it simultaneously positions African governments as incapable of navigating their own geopolitical relationships.

The Praetorian Structural Argument

The consequences of this bilateral architecture are most destructive at the level of domestic governance. The consistent prioritization of military capacity over civilian institutional development produces a predictable outcome: the elevation of the military as the most resourced and externally legitimized institution in the state. This is the logical result of a model that treats military professionalization as a proxy for democratic consolidation. When external partners invest in training armed forces while ignoring courts and legislatures, the internal balance of power shifts toward the military. Nsia-Pepira identifies this as a defining feature of U.S. engagement, noting that AFRICOM's agenda produces an institutional environment in which military organizations accumulate capabilities that civilian oversight bodies cannot match (Nsia-Pepira, 2014). The result is a Praetorian condition a military cohort possessing the material capacity and external legitimacy to displace civilian authority when political conditions create

the incentive. This condition does not require an individual's intent to coup; it requires only that the structural prerequisites be in place. As the following Niger case study demonstrates, these conditions do not merely correlate with democratic instability they produce it.

Niger Case Study: General Barmou and the 2023 Coup

In the years preceding July 2023, Niger occupied a privileged position in AFRICOM's strategic architecture. U.S. officials consistently cited the country as a model partner in the Sahel, pointing to its cooperation on counterterrorism operations, its hosting of U.S. drone facilities, and the professionalization of its security forces through sustained American training programs as evidence that the security-first model was working. On July 26, 2023, the Presidential Guard overthrew President Mohamed Bazoum in a coup that ended Niger's democratic government and expelled U.S. forces from the country entirely. Among the central figures in the coup leadership was General Moussa Barmou, commander of Niger's special operations forces and one of the most extensively U.S.-trained military officers on the continent. The Intercept documented that Barmou had participated in American training programs repeatedly over the course of his career, developing not only tactical capability but the organizational networks, institutional credibility, and professional legitimacy that U.S. partnership confers on selected officers (The Intercept, 2023). His profile was precisely that of the Praetorian figure described above: an officer whose external validation had elevated him structurally above the civilian institutions nominally responsible for his oversight. The Niger coup is therefore not legible as an anomaly or a policy misfire in an otherwise sound framework. It is the structural argument made visible. The very attributes that made Barmou a valued U.S. partner his capability, his organizational authority, and his external legitimacy were the same attributes that made him capable of displacing the government that U.S. policy had simultaneously claimed to be strengthening. Niger did not fail despite American engagement. The conditions for its democratic collapse were built incrementally through it.



Figure 3. General Moussa Barmou attending an AFRICOM conference in Washington D.C., demonstrating the institutional legitimacy conferred on him by sustained U.S. military partnership.



Figure 4. General Barmou alongside U.S. Army Lieutenant General Braga, emblematic of the bilateral legitimization that elevated him above the civilian institutions nominally responsible for his oversight.

The Willing Participant: African Elite Co-Constitution

The structural argument advanced in the preceding sections carries an implicit risk worth addressing directly: by highlighting U.S. agency as the primary driver of militarization and democratic instability, the analysis can unintentionally reproduce a paternalistic framing in which African states appear as passive recipients of externally imposed conditions rather than actors with their own political interests and strategic calculations. A complete account of the Training-to-Coup pipeline requires recognizing that the structure is not unilaterally imposed. African political and military elites have, across multiple contexts, actively sought U.S. partnership, leveraged counterterrorism frameworks to secure external backing, and used the resources and legitimacy that American training confers to consolidate domestic power against rivals. The "War on Terror" label functions not only as a U.S. discursive instrument but as a resource that African elites strategically deploy to attract military assistance, suppress opposition movements, and insulate themselves from accountability under the cover of security imperatives. Nsia-Pepira documents this dynamic in the ACRI context, noting that the discriminatory selection criteria generated competition among African governments for U.S. partner status, with inclusion conferring material and reputational advantages that exclusion denied (Nsia-Pepira, 2014). This interdependence does not, however, dissolve the structural argument. The mutual logic of convenience that sustains the pipeline operates within an asymmetric framework that the United States designs, funds, and ultimately controls. African elites can navigate and exploit that framework, but they did not construct it and cannot fundamentally alter it through individual strategic choices. Acknowledging elite agency therefore strengthens rather than undermines the

paper's core claim: the pipeline persists not merely because the United States imposes it but because it generates incentives on both sides that reproduce the conditions for democratic instability regardless of the intentions of any individual actor within it.

Democracy Reconstructed as Market Access

The economic architecture of American Exceptionalism operates through a framework whose stated purpose is democratic development but whose operative logic is market compliance. The African Growth and Opportunity Act grants eligible sub-Saharan African nations duty-free access to U.S. markets across more than 1,800 product categories, conditioning that access on eligibility criteria that include, alongside labor rights and governance benchmarks, the explicit requirement that beneficiary nations not undermine U.S. national security or foreign policy interests and that they actively eliminate barriers to U.S. trade and investment (U.S. Committee on Ways and Means). The consequence of this structure is that the definition of democratic adequacy becomes inseparable from a country's posture toward American commercial interests. Tanzania illustrates this conflation clearly. In October 2025, the government of President Samia Suluhu Hassan oversaw a post-election crackdown of extraordinary brutality: security forces killed protesters at scale, hundreds of activists were charged with treason, bodies were removed from streets and allegedly disposed of in mass graves, and an internet blackout was imposed to suppress documentation of the violence (Paget, 2025). By any rigorous application of AGOA's stated democratic governance criteria, this conduct represented a categorical failure. Yet Tanzania retained its AGOA eligibility status through the 2025 review cycle (USTR, 2025). The explanation lies not in a failure of the review mechanism but in what Hassan's government had consistently prioritized: market openness, ease of doing business, and the removal of barriers to U.S. trade and investment (Paget, 2025). Tanzania's democratic collapse generated no trade consequences because its economic posture remained compliant. What AGOA disciplines, in practice, is not authoritarian governance but economic deviation.

Regime Discipline: Rwanda

If Tanzania's retention of AGOA eligibility following a documented massacre reveals what the framework tolerates, Rwanda's suspension reveals what it does not. In 2016, the East African Community made a collective decision to phase in a ban on imports of used clothing and footwear from the United States, with the explicit aim of developing domestic textile and manufacturing capacity across member states. Rwanda maintained that position through the subsequent U.S. review process. The Secondary Materials and Recycled Textiles Association, an American industry lobby, filed a petition arguing that the EAC ban imposed economic hardship on the U.S. used clothing industry and was inconsistent with AGOA's requirement that beneficiaries eliminate barriers to U.S. trade and investment. Following an out-of-cycle eligibility review, Rwanda's duty-free apparel benefits were suspended. Tanzania and Uganda, by contrast, retained their eligibility after both governments committed to reverse course and comply with U.S. market access demands (Tralac, 2018). Rwanda was not suspended for the systematic suppression of political opposition, for which its government has an extensively documented record. It was suspended for attempting to build a domestic industry. The Deputy U.S. Trade Representative framed Tanzania and Uganda's capitulation as a commendable exercise in corrective compliance, praising both governments for taking steps to address U.S. concerns. The geometry of this episode is precise enough to demand a direct question: if

AGOA's eligibility criteria genuinely prioritize democratic governance and human rights, why does protecting the American used clothing market trigger suspension while mass political violence does not? The evidence does not offer a reassuring answer. What it reveals instead is a disciplinary structure whose operative threshold is economic alignment, and whose democratic language functions as a legitimizing frame rather than an enforceable standard. Taken together with the Tanzania case, Rwanda completes the argument: AGOA does not reward democracy. It rewards compliance.

South Sudan Independence as Exceptionalist Project

The South Sudan case brings together every structural argument this paper has advanced. It is a site where humanitarian framing masked strategic calculation, where military assistance preceded and ultimately undermined civilian institutional development, and where the Logic of Appropriateness allowed the United States to perform the role of liberator while pursuing objectives that had little to do with the self-determination of the South Sudanese people. The foundation of U.S. involvement in Sudan predates the independence moment by decades. Autesserre (2002) documents how, throughout the 1990s, the United States deployed food aid as a covert instrument of proxy warfare channeling humanitarian assistance through NGOs operating outside the UN's Operation Lifeline Sudan framework in order to sustain the Sudan People's Liberation Movement (SPLA/M) militarily without openly backing a rebel army whose human rights record made direct support politically untenable. The humanitarian channel was chosen precisely because its appearance of neutrality disarmed diplomatic protest and concealed what Autesserre describes as a deliberate strategy of supporting the rebels enough to keep Khartoum off-balance, but not enough to allow them to win. This strategic ambiguity was not a failure of policy coherence but its defining feature: a prolonged conflict served U.S. interests more effectively than a resolution would have. When South Sudan achieved independence in 2011, the United States framed the outcome as the culmination of a principled commitment to self-determination a humanitarian achievement consistent with its identity as the indispensable defender of freedom. The framing was not entirely false, but it was incomplete in ways that mattered. U.S. support for South Sudanese independence was simultaneously a decades-long tactical project aimed at dismantling the Islamist government in Khartoum, securing access to the region's oil infrastructure, and extending American influence into a strategically contested corridor of East Africa. The Exceptionalist narrative of liberation provided the discursive framework through which these material objectives could be pursued without triggering the scrutiny that an openly strategic intervention would have invited. South Sudan did not become independent despite U.S. strategic interests. It became independent partly because of them.

Security Assistance and the Civil War

South Sudan represents the most complete expression of the Praetorian dynamic established previously. Where Niger demonstrated how U.S. military training produced the individual capability and institutional legitimacy required for a coup, South Sudan demonstrates what happens when that same logic operates at the scale of an entire state formation process. The 2005 Comprehensive Peace Agreement, strongly backed by the United States, cemented the SPLA/M's organizational hegemony over South Sudanese political life while paying almost no attention to the civilian institutional infrastructure that a viable democratic state requires. Temin documents that the agreement effectively endorsed the power of the gun at the expense of civic associations,

political opposition, and civilian oversight bodies, installing an unaccountable military leadership whose only organizational experience lay in armed struggle (Temin, 2018). The United States, as the agreement's primary external backer, had maximum leverage during the interim period between the CPA's signing and South Sudan's independence referendum to demand democratic reform and civilian institutional development. It did not use that leverage. Former officials interviewed by Temin acknowledge that the SPLA/M was shown repeatedly that it could behave with impunity, and that the sense of unquestioned U.S. backing was built into South Sudanese leaders' calculations before the state was even formally established (Temin, 2018). When civil war erupted in December 2013, the structural conditions had been in place for years: a bloated, fragmented security sector with little loyalty to centralized civilian command, a political class whose only model of authority was military dominance, and an external patron whose longstanding relationships with SPLA/M leadership consistently overrode consequence-based policy assessment. The civil war was not a failure of an otherwise sound framework. It was the predictable outcome of a state-building process that prioritized security partnership over civilian legitimacy from the outset, producing precisely the institutional environment in which military actors accumulate the capacity, the incentive, and ultimately the justification to resolve political competition through force. South Sudan did not collapse despite U.S. engagement. The structural conditions for its collapse were constructed incrementally through it.

Stripping the Mask: Summary of Findings

This paper has argued that American Exceptionalism functions not merely as a set of beliefs about U.S. superiority but as an operational mechanism that enables a specific and reproducible structure of harm. The causal chain runs as follows. The United States constructs an identity as the indispensable defender of liberal democratic order an identity whose behavioral logic, the Logic of Appropriateness, compels it to perform the role of benevolent partner regardless of whether that performance produces the outcomes it claims to pursue. This identity grants the U.S. the classificatory authority to define what counts as stability, democracy, and legitimate governance, imposing those definitions on African states through bilateral security arrangements that systematically bypass existing continental and regional frameworks. The military architecture produced by this engagement documented across AFRICOM's network of cooperative security locations, its humanitarian deployments, and its training programs is not designed to build civilian institutional capacity. It is designed to produce militarily capable, externally legitimized security forces whose organizational strength structurally outpaces the civilian oversight bodies nominally responsible for their accountability. The predictable result, demonstrated in Niger and displayed at state-formation scale in South Sudan, is a Praetorian condition in which democratic governance becomes structurally precarious not despite U.S. engagement but through it. The economic architecture of AGOA extends this same logic into the trade domain, disciplining African states not for democratic failure but for economic deviation as the Rwanda-Tanzania contrast makes unmistakably clear. What prevents this structure from generating accountability is precisely the identity that animates it. As long as the United States is performing the role of the responsible, benevolent global leader, the Logic of Appropriateness insulates its policy from consequence-based evaluation. The narrative of the Good Guy is not incidental to the harm this paper has documented. It is the mechanism through which that harm is sustained, legitimized, and rendered systematically invisible to the domestic and international audiences who might otherwise demand a reckoning.

The Prescriptive Pivot: Total Neutrality

The structural argument advanced in this paper does not lead toward a prescription for better U.S. policy. It leads toward a prescription for African sovereign agency. If the harm documented across these sections is produced not by individual policy failures but by the structural logic of external dependency, then the remedy cannot be found in reforming the external actor. It must be found in dismantling the conditions that make external dependency structurally advantageous to African political elites in the first place. Pan-Africanism provides the philosophical and institutional framework for that project. As a political tradition, Pan-Africanism has always understood that formal independence without substantive economic and security sovereignty reproduces the hierarchical relations of colonialism under new administrative arrangements. Nkrumah's concept of Total Neutrality, developed in the context of Cold War great-power competition, articulates precisely this insight: that African states cannot develop genuine political identities while their security architectures, economic frameworks, and diplomatic alignments remain organized around the strategic interests of external powers (Nkrumah, 1970). The contemporary relevance of that argument is not diminished by its historical origin. The great-power competition that AFRICOM's posture statements frame as a threat to African stability is, from a Pan-Africanist perspective, itself the problem. Whether the external actor is the United States, China, or Russia, the structural consequence of conscription into competing great-power frameworks is the same: African political development is subordinated to external strategic calculation, and the bilateral dependencies that result generate precisely the incentive structures that sustain the Praetorian pipeline and the AGOA compliance dynamic this paper has documented. The alternative is not isolation but reorientation. The African Union's Peace and Security Architecture, the ECOWAS Policy Framework on Security Sector Reform, and the East African Community's regional security protocols already provide the multilateral institutional infrastructure for a genuinely African-governed security order. Total Neutrality, understood through a Pan-Africanist framework, means investing the political will and material resources in these structures that African governments currently expend on bilateral arrangements with external powers. It means refusing the classificatory authority that American Exceptionalism claims over African governance not through confrontation but through the construction of institutional alternatives robust enough to render that authority structurally irrelevant. The prescription is not that Africa turns away from the world. It is that Africa turns toward itself.

Final Significance

This paper began with a gap: the distance between the official language of a light footprint and the physical reality of a sprawling military network. That gap, it has argued, is not an oversight or a failure of transparency. It is the product of a deliberate conceptual framework a system for managing what can be known, said, and challenged about U.S. engagement in Africa. The light footprint designation is one instrument in that architecture. The indispensable nation identity is another. The classificatory power to define failed states and strategic partners is another still. AGOA's democratic language, which disciplines economic deviation while tolerating mass political violence, is another. Each of these instruments operates on the same underlying logic: the authority to define reality is the authority to determine what requires justification and what does not. As long as the United States can name its military network a series of cooperative security locations, its proxy engagements acts of partnership, and its economic conditionality a reward for democratic progress, the structure this paper has documented remains insulated from

the scrutiny it would otherwise attract. Dismantling that structure therefore requires more than institutional reform or policy revision. It requires the construction of an alternative framework one developed from within African intellectual and political traditions, grounded in the historical experience of those who have lived under the arrangements this paper has analyzed, and capable of generating its own categories of analysis, legitimacy, and sovereignty that do not depend on external validation for their authority. The question this paper ultimately poses is not whether the United States will reform its Africa policy. History suggests it will not, at least not in response to the kind of deteriorating security outcomes documented here, because the Logic of Appropriateness renders those outcomes politically secondary to the performance of appropriate behavior. The question is whether African states, institutions, and intellectual traditions can build the conceptual and organizational infrastructure to make the architecture of American Exceptionalism structurally less effective, less necessary, and ultimately less legible as a framework for understanding African political reality at all. The light footprint, in the end, is not a description of how lightly the United States treads. It is a description of how completely the terms of the conversation have been controlled. Reclaiming those terms is where genuine sovereignty begins.

Annotated Bibliography

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7. Wight, C., & Joseph, J. (2024). 'The New Geopolitics of Africa: Hegemony, Multipolarity and the Contest for Sovereignty.' *International Affairs*.

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Used in Paragraphs 7 and 18. Documents the continental multilateral framework that U.S. bilateral engagement displaces. Essential for the epistemic violence argument and the Total Neutrality prescription.

9. ECOWAS. *Policy Framework on Security Sector Reform and Governance*.

Used in Paragraphs 7 and 18. Establishes the West African regional framework sidelined by U.S. bilateral security arrangements.

10. East African Community African Transitional Justice Hub.

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